Draft: pending clinical review

Fever and pain medicine for your child

The right dose for your child's weight, and when to get help

The 5 things to remember

- Fever helps the body fight infection. Medicine is to make your child **comfortable**, not to bring the number down.
- Give the dose by your child's **weight**, using the **syringe** that comes with the medicine. Never a kitchen spoon.
- Paracetamol: every 4–6 hours, **no more than 4 doses** in 24 hours. Ibuprofen: every 6–8 hours, **no more than 3 doses** in 24 hours.
- **Check the strength** on the bottle. Syrups and drops come in different strengths.
- Under **3 months** with a temperature of 38 °C or more: see a doctor **now**.

Which medicine should I use?

- **Paracetamol** (Adol, Panadol, Fevadol): from birth. Ask a doctor first for a baby under 3 months.
- **Ibuprofen** (Brufen, Nurofen): from 3 months and 5 kg. Not if your child is dehydrated, has kidney problems or chickenpox.
- Use **one** medicine. Switch only if your child is still upset before the next dose is due. Never give both at once.
- Different brand names can be the **same medicine**. Never give two paracetamol products.

How much do I give?

Child's weight	Paracetamol drops 100 mg/mL	Paracetamol syrup 120 mg/5 mL	Paracetamol syrup 250 mg/5 mL	Ibuprofen syrup 100 mg/5 mL
6 kg	0.9 mL	3.5 mL	1.5 mL	3 mL
8 kg	1.2 mL	5 mL	2 mL	4 mL
10 kg	1.5 mL	6 mL	3 mL	5 mL
12 kg	1.8 mL	7.5 mL	3.5 mL	6 mL
15 kg	-	9 mL	4.5 mL	7.5 mL
20 kg	-	12.5 mL	6 mL	10 mL
25 kg	-	15.5 mL	7.5 mL	12.5 mL
30 kg	-	18.5 mL	9 mL	15 mL

Find the weight closest to your child's, **without going over it**. Over 30 kg: ask your doctor or pharmacist.

Good to know

- Light clothes and a comfortable room are enough. No heavy blankets.
- Do not sponge with cold water or alcohol. It makes children shiver and does not help.
- Offer drinks often. Breastfeed as usual.

Get help now; call 997 or go to the emergency department if your child:

- Is under 3 months old with a temperature of 38 °C or more.
- Is very sleepy, floppy, or hard to wake.
- Is breathing fast or hard, or grunting.
- Has a rash that does not fade when you press a glass on it.
- Has a fit (seizure), a stiff neck, or has had too much medicine by mistake.

See a doctor soon (or call 937 for advice) if:

- The fever lasts more than 5 days.
- Your child is drinking much less or passing much less urine.
- You are worried, or your child seems to be getting worse.

My child's plan

Weight (kg) and date weighed: _____

Medicine and strength · dose (mL) · how often · most doses in 24 h: _____

Doses given

#	Day and time	Medicine	Dose (mL)
1			
2			
3			

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This leaflet gives general information. It does not replace advice from your own doctor, who knows your health. Bring it to your next visit and ask about anything that is unclear. Written with AI assistance, checked by the medical editor, and still under review with colleagues.

Last updated: November 2026 · **Next review:** November 2027, or sooner if guidance changes

Sources:

1. National Institute for Health and Care Excellence. Fever in under 5s: assessment and initial management (NG143), 2019, updated 2021
2. Sullivan JE, Farrar HC; AAP Section on Clinical Pharmacology and Therapeutics. Fever and antipyretic use in children. Pediatrics 2011;127:580–7
3. Product information: paracetamol oral suspension 120 mg/5 mL and 250 mg/5 mL, paracetamol drops 100 mg/mL, ibuprofen oral suspension 100 mg/5 mL
4. British National Formulary for Children (BNFc): paracetamol and ibuprofen